Echoing the heroic struggles of Marvel's wall-crawling Spider-Man, there are two paths available to those presented great power: Tony Stark's path was decided after an epiphany to use his incredible genius for the world's betterment. Stane's path was decided when he prized seizing power over maintaining his humanity. Their final clash in the pages of *Iron Man* is legend.

Iron Man's battle with the Iron Monger foreshadowed the coming of the "Armor Wars," where the philosophical questions of Stark's complicity as a weapons manufacturer were first posed. When Tony's technology is further co-opted by forces bent on destruction, Iron Man goes on a mad dash across the world to destroy any instance of his armor proliferation — whether wielded by foe or friend.

Other major stories and characters highlight 45 years of tales of suspense, including Iron Man's many tête-à-têtes with Doctor Doom, the evolution of his friendship with pilot Jim Rhodes, the coming of War Machine and more classic adventures with the Avengers than can be counted. Recent triumphs have included the definitive mark made by Warren Ellis and Adi Granov's "Extremis" run, which helped inform the visual look for Jon Favreau's feature film. Through it all, Tony Stark has proven to be one of Marvel's deepest and most interesting characters, and his heroic alter ego has inspired talented creators and excited legions of fans. And it's amazing to think that all this history has been made by a guy with no super-powers at all. Just a suit of armor and a big brain housing designs for the world's brightest possible future. For a man of armor, Tony Stark has always exhibited an unalloyed heroism.



Art by Carlo Pagulayan,
from *All-New Iron Manual* (July 2008)